themselves about the righteousness of the cause for which their services had been enlisted.

The ambitious P.C. Alexander

P.C. Alexander belonged to the first category. A highly successful IAS officer of the 1948 batch (Madras, first batch of IAS, post-Independence), he held a number of important posts and assignments during his career. After working in his home cadre and in various ministries at New Delhi, he became Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's principal secretary in May 1981 and continued to serve in that capacity with Rajiv Gandhi till January 1985, when he had to resign after the infamous Coomar Narain spy scandal, in which his personal secretary and two assistants were involved. [1] , [2] They were caught passing on copies of top-secret documents received by Alexander to their handlers linked to some embassies located in New Delhi. Originating from highly sensitive departments such as the R&AW, Atomic Energy Commission and India's space agency, ISRO, their safe custody was Alexander's to ensure.

In terms of the scandal's impact on the R&AW, in addition to the leakage of sensitive information contained in those notes, the names of issuing officers (including my own), their designations and areas of responsibility were also compromised. Following that, it was decided that the R&AW officers authorized to issue such notes would use their designations only and not their names. From that day onwards, a number of officers working in the R&AW, a department directly under the charge of the prime minster, became truly nameless and faceless entities, even for the PM's office.

It was a serious lapse on Alexander's part. He got away only with his resignation from the post of principal secretary to the PM, with his PS and two assistants going to jail. He was soon rehabilitated and sent to London for two years (1985–87) as India's high commissioner. On his return, he was appointed governor of Tamil Nadu (1988–90) and then of Maharashtra (1993–2002). The NDA (National Democratic Alliance) government led by Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee wanted to nominate him to the post of president of India in 2002. But the proposal fell through because of